seemed no reason that my literary output and earnings could not continue at this high level and between that and my savings, which had now reached $16,000, I would certainly never be in want and I would always be able to support my wife and child.

It was a good feeling—and none too soon, since I was about to turn thirty-three.

7

We spent New Year's Eve 1952-53 at the house of our friends Harold and Zelda Goodglass, making our way there through a sleet-storm. (I remember very few decent New Year's Eves, when it came to driving.)

What I remember best about that particular New Year's Eve party was that one guest, a rather loud, opinionated fellow to whom I took an instant dislike (since Fm a rather loud, opinionated fellow myself), began to lecture me on science fiction.

He was a recent convert and didn't really know much on the subject, but apparently he was overwhelmed at the imaginative character of it. He said to me, "Do you understand how much imagination you have to have to write science fiction? Can you grasp"—here he tapped his head as though urging me to think it through—"how creatively you have to think? Why, in order to write science fiction . . ."

He went on and on. I kept a polite look of interest on my face, saying "My, my," and "Really," every once in a while, and my host and hostess had a hard job to maintain their composure. The others there didn't know me—except Gertrude, of course, and she was in the kitchen and had been since the fellow had started talking on the subject.

She came out as he was at the peak of his peroration, listened a few moments in puzzlement, and said, "Why are you saying all this? My husband is Isaac Asimov."

And then I laughed. I couldn't help it.

The fellow was furious, naturally. He never said another word to me for the duration and he probably stopped reading science fiction after that.

8